Competencies for Leaders in Education versus Other Industry Groups: Is Teresa Sullivan Right?

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Abstract

Leadership competencies are used to assess and develop managers in a variety of organizations. The ousting and reinstatement of University of Virginia (UVA) President Teresa Sullivan is an excellent example of a disagreement over the competencies that are valued for leaders in education. The UVA Board of Visitors' Rector demanded leadership competencies more typical for the private sector, while President Sullivan maintained such approaches would not work in a great university. In this study, the competency priorities as rated by incumbent managers were analyzed in education, banking & finance, retail, manufacturing, government, and healthcare industry groups, to identify differences in the importance ratings between education and the other groups. The analysis identifies significant uniformity of competency importance ratings among banking/finance, healthcare, manufacturing, and retail, but found education and government to be different from the private industry groups, as well as each other. Application of competency priorities from the private sector into educational organizations may lead to negative effects.

Introduction

Teresa Sullivan, president of the University of Virginia (UVA), was ousted and reinstated in June of 2012 by the UVA Board of Visitors, an elected body of successful business and community leaders from outside the University, due to philosophical differences regarding the leadership behaviors required to lead a great university in times of change. According to the Rector of the UVA Board of Visitors, the competency deficiencies displayed by Sullivan were her unwillingness to approach the University with "a much faster pace of change in administrative structure, in governance, in financial resource development and in resource prioritization and allocation" (Dragas, 2012). Instead, she approached the institution with an incremental pace of change, generating support from different constituency groups across the University of Virginia.

Sullivan stated in her address to the board that "corporate-style, top-down leadership does not work in a great university. Sustained change with buy-in does" (Sullivan, 2012). This study explores the differences in leadership behaviors as they are valued in education versus the behaviors most highly valued in other public and private industry groups, including: government, healthcare, banking & finance, retail, and manufacturing organizations.

Background

Competencies are clusters of behaviors that are associated with one another. In work settings, competencies are utilized as metrics for documenting performance and planning development of employees. In the case of leadership assessment and development, competency models define those behaviors of a person which are associated with effective leadership (Boyatzis and Saatcigolu, 2007; Spendlove, 2007; Cragg and Spurgeon, 2007). Organizations and researchers develop competency models to identify the behaviors that increase the effectiveness of a leader (Chung-Herrera, 2003; Lucia and Lepsinger, 1999; Sparks and Gentry, 2008). The competencies which contribute to successful leadership vary by managerial level and by job function (Sparks and Gentry, 2008; Wolverton, Ackerman, & Holt, 2005).

Currently there is no management competency model which accurately fits all aspects of every industry sector. With the limited research available, this allows for a handful of theories. Frankel, Schechtman, and Koenigs (2006) found that "the values of the education industry are at least somewhat different from those of publicly traded companies" (p. 520), and noted that challenges specific to education, such as the interfering role of political stakeholders and the demands of the community, require a different type of leadership than the for-profit world. By contrast, Cragg and Spurgeon (2007) found that competencies which were largely derived from the private sector were transferable to the public sector, and Sparks and Gentry (2008) found that the importance, or non-importance, of specific competencies stayed fairly consistent across different types of organizations, including manufacturing, finance, healthcare, transportation, wholesale/retail trade, private and public nonprofit.

Research Questions

- *Q1: What are the leadership competencies rated as most important for leaders in education organizations?*
- *Q2: What are the leadership competencies rated as most important for leaders in manufacturing, banking/finance, retail, healthcare, and government industry groups?*
- *Q3: How do the leadership competencies for education organizations compare to those for the other industry groups?*

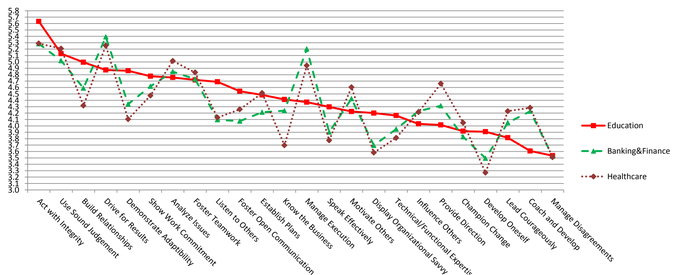
Results

The three most important competencies for education leaders were ***act with integrity, use sound judgment,*** **and** ***build relationships***. In the manufacturing, banking/finance, and retail industry sectors, the three highest rated competencies were ***drive for results, act with integrity,*** **and** ***manage execution***. Government managers indicated that the three most important competencies were ***act with integrity, use sound judgment,*** **and** ***analyze issues***. Out of the 24 competencies rated, importance ratings in education were different in 23 of 24. Table 1 displays the top three and bottom three competencies in five industry sectors.

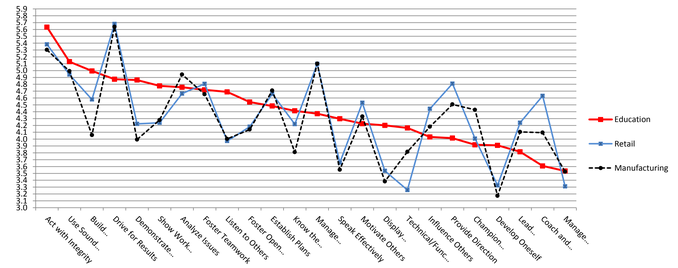
Table 1
Relative Importance of Competencies in Education Versus Other Industry Groups

Industry Sector	Education Higher	Mean Adjusted	Education Lower	Mean Adjusted
Government D=1.01	Establish Plans	.16	Analyze Issues	.16
	Champion Change	.09	Manage Disagreement	.11
	Develop Oneself	.09	Provide Direction	.10
Manufacturing D=1.18	Demonstrate Adaptability	.20	Drive for Results	.35
	Build Relationships	.15	Manage Disagreements	.17
	Display Organizational Savvy	.14	Coach and Develop	.16
Retail D=1.27	Technical/Functional Expertise	.17	Drive for Results	.36
	Motivate Others	.14	Coach and Develop	.36
	Sound Judgment	.13	Provide Direction	.13
Banking/Finance D=.92	Establish Plans	.19	Manage Execution	.24
	Listen to Others	.12	Drive for Results	.22
	Demonstrate Adaptability	.12	Coach and Develop	.20
Healthcare D=.87	Demonstrate Adaptability	.13	Drive for Results	.14
	Know the Business	.12	Analyze Issues	.12
	Build Relationships	.09	Coach and Develop	.11

Comparison of Education, Banking/Finance & Healthcare



Comparison of Education, Retail & Manufacturing



Methods

Data for this study were drawn from an archival database of multisource feedback. Responses from individuals in leadership roles, their direct supervisors, peers, and direct reports were collected as leaders participated in leadership development initiatives in the years 2003 – 2008. Participants signed consent forms allowing their data to be used in aggregate for research.

The data included 14,201 managers. There were 588 managers working in Education organizations, 2042 in Government, 2072 in Healthcare, 1386 in Retail, 3704 in Manufacturing, and 4409 in Banking/Finance. Participants were 75.7% male, 24.3% female. The mean age is 43.91 years (SD=13.98). Approximately 90% of managers held a bachelor's degree or higher.

The PROFILOR® for Managers, a multisource feedback instrument, was used to gather the behavioral data for this study (PDI Ninth House, 2004). The PROFILOR® for Managers contains 135 specific behaviors, grouped by the publisher into 24 competency scales. Median internal consistency reliabilities for PROFILOR® for Managers scales range from 0.75 for the self-perspective to 0.90 for the direct report perspective. The competencies in the questionnaire are intended to represent behavioral performance competencies required of managers generally. Because of the potential for different competencies to be more important in various industries, participants and their direct supervisors completed a competency importance ranking. This provided the data examined in this study.

Discussion

Our research demonstrates that management competencies in education are definitely different from those in other industry groups. Behaviors in the three highest-priority competencies for education are consistent with the leadership approach described by President Sullivan (Sullvan, 2012). By contrast, the behaviors in the three highest-priority competencies for manufacturing, banking/finance, and retail are consistent with the leadership approach demanded by Rector Dragas (Dragas, 2012).

The competency priority results raise the question of what is the appropriate management model for universities. According to our findings, the traditional corporate top-down management approach is not consistent with expectations of individuals in educational organizations, and may lead to negative responses like those experienced at UVA. (illustrated below)



Image of President Teresa Sullivan walks through crowd of supporters as she is re-instated into office.
(Photo By Norm Shafer/ For The Washington Post) Norm Shafer / For the Washington Post